

Oman 2024 Human Rights Report

Executive Summary

There were no significant changes in the human rights situation in Oman during the year.

Significant human rights issues included credible reports of arbitrary arrest or detention and serious restrictions on freedom of expression and media freedom, including censorship.

The government took credible steps to identify and punish officials who committed human rights abuses.

Section 1. Life

a. Extrajudicial Killings

There were no reports the government or its agents committed arbitrary or unlawful killings during the year.

b. Coercion in Population Control

There were no reports of coerced abortion or involuntary sterilization by government authorities.

Section 2. Liberty

a. Freedom of the Press

The law provided for limited freedom of expression for citizens and members of the press and other media, including citizen journalists, but authorities did not always respect even these constrained rights.

Journalists, high-profile figures, and writers reportedly exercised self-censorship. The sultan issued a new media law in November that human rights groups stated contained broad and vague terms granting the information ministry authority to further restrict freedom of expression, including of journalists, by broadening the range of activities that could be punished.

The law prohibited criticism of the sultan in any form or medium, as well as any “provocative propaganda to undermine the prestige of the state,” electronic communications that “might prejudice the public order or religious values,” and “defamation of character.” The law prohibited insulting not only the sultan, his wife, and children but also a public official or private citizen. Authorities prosecuted individuals for writing about the sultan in a way the government perceived to be negative. The law prohibited statements hostile to Islam or denigrating Islamic values, and authorities prosecuted individuals for comments insulting Islam. The law also criminalized “inciting sectarian strife,” which could prohibit certain

forms of religious observance or expressions of group identity. The government censored publicly shown films, primarily for sexual content and nudity, and placed restrictions on performances in public venues. The law also prohibited dancing in restaurants and entertainment venues without a permit.

The Oman Center for Human Rights and Democracy reported activist Saeed Jaddad was arrested on April 15 in connection to posts he made on X critical of the government. On June 11, he was given a suspended two-year sentence.

Censorship by Governments, Military, Intelligence, or Police Forces, Criminal Groups, or Armed Extremist or Rebel Groups

Media did not operate freely. Authorities tolerated very limited criticism of government officials in privately owned newspapers and magazines, and editorials generally were consistent with the government's views.

Authorities permitted expressions of frustration with problems such as unemployment or living conditions but generally prohibited direct criticism of sitting ministers. Authorities required journalists to obtain a license to practice their profession; freelance journalists and citizen journalists were ineligible for a license and not recognized as journalists under the law.

Headlines in both public and private print media outlets were subject to an official review and approval before publication, but specific details regarding

the review process were unknown. Journalists and writers reported they exercised self-censorship. The law permitted the Ministry of Information to review all media products, including books produced within or imported into the country. The ministry occasionally prohibited or censored material from domestic and imported publications viewed as politically, culturally, or sexually offensive. According to the Omani Center for Human Rights and Democracy, the ministry banned distribution of several books by Omani and international authors at the Muscat International Book Fair in February.

b. Worker Rights

Freedom of Association and Collective Bargaining

The law provided for workers to form and join unions, bargain collectively, and conduct legal strikes, and prohibited antiunion discrimination, but with restrictions. The law required all unions to affiliate with the General Federation of Oman Workers, which represented unions in regional and international fora. No independent organized labor unions existed. The law required a minimum of 25 workers to form a union, regardless of company size. The law required three-quarters of an enterprise's employees to approve a strike with notice to employers three weeks in advance of the intended strike date. Strikes were not permitted in the oil and gas industry, ports, airports, or public transport facilities. The law prohibited employers from firing or imposing other penalties on employees for union activity.

Employers did not face penalties for dismissing workers for organizing efforts, in great part because it was difficult to legally prove a firing was for union organizing. The law did not require reinstatement for workers fired for union activity. While government-approved unions were open to all legal workers regardless of nationality, the law prohibited members of the armed forces, other public security institutions, government employees, domestic workers, as well as individuals convicted of criminal activity or acts against the security of the country or national unity from forming or joining unions.

The law prohibited unions from accepting grants or financial assistance from any source without the government's approval. The government generally enforced applicable laws effectively, and penalties were commensurate with those for other laws involving civil rights but were rarely enforced.

Forced or Compulsory Labor

See the Department of State's annual *Trafficking in Persons Report* at <https://www.state.gov/trafficking-in-persons-report/>.

Acceptable Work Conditions

Wage and Hour Laws

The law provided for a minimum wage only for citizens. The minimum wage did not apply to small businesses employing fewer than five persons,

dependent family members working for a family firm, and some categories of manual labor. The minimum wage exceeded the World Bank International Poverty Line. The law provided for a regular workweek of 40 hours, and it required 125 percent of regular pay for overtime work and 150 percent of regular pay for overtime night work. Work on weekly rest days or official holidays required a bonus equal to the worker's daily basic wage or compensatory leave. A 30-hour workweek applied for Muslim workers during the month of Ramadan.

After introducing an electronic wage protection system in 2023, in January the Ministry of Labor required all companies to register with the system within 55 days. The system mandated that private sector employers transfer workers' wages to local banks within a fixed timeframe. The level of enforcement or compliance, especially for small enterprises, was unknown.

Occupational Safety and Health

There were occupational safety and health (OSH) standards generally appropriate for the main industries in the country: oil and gas, fishing, and trade. The government proactively identified unsafe conditions and carried out inspections. While workers could remove themselves from situations that endangered health or safety without jeopardy to their employment, there were reports the government did not always enforce standards for low-wage foreign workers, particularly for domestic workers.

During the summer months, the Ministry of Labor prohibited outdoor work from 12:30 to 3:30 pm. Local media reported several firms were fined for violations.

Wage, Hour, and OSH Enforcement

The government effectively enforced the minimum wage, hour, and OSH laws for citizens, but neither wage and hour nor OSH regulations applied to domestic workers, who were exclusively noncitizens. Penalties for violations were commensurate with those for similar crimes, such as fraud, and were sometimes applied against violators.

The Ministry of Labor enforced wage, hour, and OSH laws. The number of labor inspectors was sufficient to enforce compliance, and inspectors had the authority to make unannounced inspections and initiate sanctions.

Foreign workers were vulnerable to poor, dangerous, or exploitative working conditions. There were reports migrant laborers in some firms and households worked more than 12 hours a day without a day off and for below-market wages. Diplomatic missions reported employers often canceled the employment contracts of seriously sick or injured foreign workers and failed to pay for their treatment, forcing them to return to their countries of origin or remain in the country illegally. A new Ministry of Labor inspection unit inaugurated during the year was granted judicial authority for enforcement in some cases, although media reports

emphasized its role in policing unauthorized foreign employment instead of occupational safety. Some labor inspections reportedly focused on enforcing visa violations and deporting those in an irregular work-visa status rather than verifying safe and adequate work conditions. Employers had a great deal of control over workers in the informal sector, particularly domestic workers who were not explicitly covered by the updated 2023 labor law. Although expatriates were not legally required to obtain a “no-objection certificate” to secure new work upon completion or termination of their employment contracts, workers who left their jobs without the consent of their employer could be punished with fines, deportation, or re-entry bans. There were reports of workers encountering bureaucratic obstacles to legally changing employers after completing their contracts.

There were no maximum legal limits on working hours nor any mandatory rest periods for domestic workers, although the contract between the employer and worker could specify such requirements. Some domestic workers were subjected to abusive conditions, including nonpayment of wages; restriction of movement; physical, verbal, and sexual abuse; contract switching; excessive work hours; denial of food; passport confiscation; and threats of use of force, arrest and detention by police. A Malawian woman domestic worker featured in an October 2023 BBC documentary on the situation of domestic workers in Oman died during the year. NGOs reported her death was linked to abuse she suffered at the hands of her employer.

The Oman Human Rights Commission stated in response to the BBC

coverage that the worker died of natural causes and there was no criminal suspicion.

World Economics estimated the size of the country's informal economy was approximately 20 percent of GDP. The government did not publish statistics on informal employment; however, some workers were employed informally in making handicrafts, small-scale retail, fishing, and family farming. The government did not monitor or enforce labor laws for the informal sector.

c. Disappearance and Abduction

Disappearance

There were no credible reports of enforced disappearances by or on behalf of government authorities.

Prolonged Detention without Charges

The law prohibited arbitrary arrest and detention and provided for the right of any persons to challenge the lawfulness of their arrest or detention in court. The government generally observed these requirements. The nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) Omani Centre for Human Rights and Democracy, the Gulf Centre for Human Rights, and MENA Rights Group, however, reported the government arbitrarily arrested peaceful activists whose public criticism of the government violated the law.

On September 25 Nasser al-Riyami from al Jabal al-Akhdar was summoned by the Internal Security Service (ISS) for interrogation related to his encounter with British-era unexploded ordnance in a region that had, during the British era, been involved in a tribal revolt against the then-Sultan. Al-Riyami remained in detention without charge as of November 22, according to the latest social media post discussing his case.

On June 16, authorities arrested Ali Amer al-Maashani, a Sunni Islamic education teacher from the eponymous Maashani tribe, for organizing Eid al-Adha prayers on the Saudi schedule one day before the official June 17 celebration of the holiday in the country as instructed by the Ibadi religious authorities. A retired schoolteacher from the same tribe, Saeed al-Maashani, was also arrested for leading early Eid prayers at his home. The Gulf Center for Human Rights reported several other individuals from this tribe were arrested in the following days either for participation in Eid prayers or social media posts.

On request of these detainees' families, hundreds of men from the Maashani tribe gathered in the town of Taqah on June 21 and released a statement demanding the detainees' release and that the country follow the Saudi Eid calendar. Dozens of attendees were reportedly arrested and were not released until they promised not to violate government policies, according to NGOs.

d. Violations in Religious Freedom

See the Department of State's annual *International Religious Freedom Report* at <https://www.state.gov/religiousfreedomreport/>.

e. Trafficking in Persons

See the Department of State's annual *Trafficking in Persons Report* at <https://www.state.gov/trafficking-in-persons-report/>.

Section 3. Security of the Person

a. Torture and Cruel, Inhuman, or Degrading Treatment or Punishment

The law prohibited such practices, and there were no credible reports government officials employed them.

b. Protection of Children

Child Labor

See the Department of Labor's *Findings on the Worst Forms of Child Labor* at <https://www.dol.gov/agencies/ilab/resources/reports/child-labor/findings/>.

Child Marriage

The minimum age of legal marriage was 18, and the government generally enforced the law, although exceptions were allowed with the consent of both a judge and a guardian, generally following an appeal by the family. There were reports that child marriage sometimes occurred in rural communities.

c. Protection to Refugees

The government generally did not allow asylum seekers to remain in the country. Office of the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) personnel occasionally visited the country. According to UNHCR, the Omani Committee for International Humanitarian Law adjudicated matters of refugees and displaced persons.

Provision of First Asylum

The law provided for the granting of asylum or refugee status, and the government had a system for providing protection to refugees. The Royal Oman Police system for granting asylum and resettlement was not transparent, and the law did not specify a timeframe in which authorities were required to adjudicate an asylum application. It was official policy not to recognize refugees from conflict zones such as Yemen, but the government provided temporary admission to certain Yemeni citizens

seeking medical care.

d. Acts of Antisemitism and Antisemitic Incitement

There was no remaining indigenous Jewish population in the country. There were no known reports of antisemitic incidents. Local press continued to publish antisemitic articles and caricatures in response to Israeli military operations in Gaza. In February, the government-linked *Oman Daily* published a cartoon depicting a man dressed in a black coat sitting on a Jewish prayer shawl magically summoning a bloody Grim Reaper-like figure out of a black hat emblazoned with the star of David.